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PASSING OF POPE FRANCIS

After his final blessing on Easter Sunday, the frail Pope dies of a stroke. Now a battle for the Catholic Church's future begins

He's returned to the house of the Father

THE Catholic Church is facing a pivotal moment over its future after Pope Francis's death yesterday.

As the world united in mourning, manoeuvring began in Rome

By **Sam Merriman** in London and **Nick Pisa** in the Vatican

over the contest to shape the Church over the next decade and guide its billion-plus adherents.

Catholics across the globe awoke to

learn their 88-year-old spiritual leader had passed away after months of ill health, as the Church's most senior clerics began descending on the Vatican to appoint his successor.

Pope Francis 'returned to the house of the Father' after dedicating his life to the service of God, the Vatican

said, in a statement that many had been dreading.

The King joined world leaders in paying tribute, having had a brief audience with Francis during a state visit to Italy this month. Sir Keir Starmer said that while the Pope was

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